poem for Akbar to recite in the mosque. According to Badauni, however, the emperor could not read it. Akbar ‘stammered and trembled . . . [and] came quickly down’, held up by others, having only managed to read three verses of Faizi’s elaborate composition.

Still, it may be that Akbar had made his point. The last of the verses he read was: ‘Exalted is His Majesty, Allah-u-Akbar!’[15]

Whether or not the emperor intended a play on words, their ambiguity was not lost on his critics. Was Akbar merely repeating the Muslim piety, ‘God is great’, or was he trying to suggest – and they would not put it past him – that Akbar was God?

Some years earlier, Akbar had proposed engraving the phrase on his seal and his coins, but one of his courtiers had advised against it, precisely because of the possible misunderstanding. He had offered, instead, ‘Lazikrullahi Akbaru’ – ‘To remember God is the greatest thing’ – less pithy, yes, but less ambiguous too.[16] Akbar had grumbled that surely no reasonable person would distort his meaning so, but let the matter rest. More recently, according to Badauni, Akbar had come up with a new ‘formula’: There is no God but God, and Akbar is His representative – so close to the Islamic assertion of faith in God and His Prophet as to cause ‘commotions’. Akbar had withdrawn his order. Now, wrote Badauni, only ‘a few people in the harem’ would use the phrase. Later, a poet and wit called Mulla Sheri would put the whole matter into a couplet:

The king this year has laid claim to be a Prophet, after the lapse of a year, please God, he will become God![17]

It wasn’t very long, in fact, before Akbar followed his detractors’ fears to their logical conclusion and declared himself the religious head of his empire.

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In September 1579, only two months after Faizi composed a poem for Akbar’s khutba, his father Shaikh Mubarak drafted what has come to be called the ‘Infallibility Decree’. Technically, the document was a ‘*mahzar*’, an opinion or a petition, declaring that the court ulema, having given the matter much thought, had decided that a just ruler (‘*sultan-i-adil*’) was ‘higher in the eyes of God’ than the most learned of His devout scholars, a